

## WEEK 16

### SUNDAY

#### CYCLE 1

**First Reading.** *2 Sam. 15: 7 – 14, 24 – 30; 16: 5 – 13*

*Rebellion of Absalom and the flight of David.*

**A reading from the second book of Samuel.**

And at the end of four years Ab'salom said to the king, "Pray let me go and pay my vow, which I have vowed to the LORD, in Hebron. For your servant vowed a vow while I dwelt at Geshur in Aram, saying, 'If the LORD will indeed bring me back to Jerusalem, then I will offer worship to the LORD.'" The king said to him, "Go in peace." So he arose, and went to Hebron.

But Ab'salom sent secret messengers throughout all the tribes of Israel, saying, "As soon as you hear the sound of the trumpet, then say, 'Ab'salom is king at Hebron!'" With Ab'salom went two hundred men from Jerusalem who were invited guests, and they went in their simplicity, and knew nothing. And while Ab'salom was offering the sacrifices, he sent for Ahith'ophel the Gi'lonite, David's counsellor, from his city Giloh. And the conspiracy grew strong, and the people with Ab'salom kept increasing.

And a messenger came to David, saying, "The hearts of the men of Israel have gone after Ab'salom." Then David said to all his servants who were with him at Jerusalem, "Arise, and let us flee; or else there will be no escape for us from Ab'salom; go in haste, lest he overtake us quickly, and bring down evil upon us, and smite the city with the edge of the sword."

And Abi'athar came up, and lo, Zadok came also, with all the Levites, bearing the ark of the covenant of God; and they set down the ark of God, until the people had all passed out of the city. Then the king said to Zadok, "Carry the ark of God back into the city. If I find favour in the eyes of the LORD, he will bring me back and let me see both it and his habitation; but if he says, 'I have no pleasure in you,' behold, here I am, let him do to me what seems good to him." The king also said to Zadok the priest, "Look, go back to the city in peace, you and Abi'athar, with your two sons, Ahim'a-az your son, and Jonathan the son of Abi'athar. See, I will wait at the fords of the wilderness, until word comes from you to inform me." So Zadok and

Abi'athar carried the ark of God back to Jerusalem; and they remained there.

But David went up the ascent of the Mount of Olives, weeping as he went, barefoot and with his head covered; and all the people who were with him covered their heads, and they went up, weeping as they went.

**Responsorial.** *Ps. 40: 10; Mk. 14: 18*

**R:** Even the friend in whom I confided, \* he who ate my bread, has raised his heel against me.

**V:** One of you, he who eats with me, will betray me,

**R:** he who ate my bread, has raised his heel against me.

**Second Reading.** *Hom. 2*

*Christ cries over the synagogue, that He loved so much.*

**A reading from the “Homilies” of St. Laurence of Brindisi, presbyter.**

The great patriarch Abraham mourned the death of his wife Sarah, and Isaac the death of his mother. The people of Israel cried for the death of Aaron the high priest and of Moses the great prophet. David cried for the death of Saul and for that of his son Absalom; so also Christ cried over Jerusalem. Who is the one who ignores that in the sacred Scriptures the synagogue is called the bride of God? Christ is God, and Jerusalem is the synagogue.

In the eyes of Christ the death of his bride is already present, therefore, “at the sight of the city, he cried over it” (Lk. 19: 41). So also David cried for Absalom: “My son! Absalom my son, my son Absalom! That I had died instead of you, Absalom, my son, my son!” (2 Sam. 19: 1): in the same way Jesus said to Jerusalem: who will give me, Jerusalem, so that I can die for you? I am in fact ready to give my life for you, so that you may be saved. David loved tenderly his son Absalom, even though he was wicked and tried to kill his father in order to take possession of the kingdom; yet he cried and desired to die for him; in the same way Christ behaved towards Jerusalem, and he cried because he saw it already near to death. He consumed himself for her, and not only did he desire to die for her salvation, but he actually died. A profound pain for Christ was the fact that while he went to die for Jerusalem in order to save the city, this city, because of its own fault, received his death not as salvation, but as a very

serious condemnation. “At the sight of the city he cried over it”. In the passion suffered on the cross Christ did not suffer so much for his own suffering and his own death as much as he did because they were men who would have never known this benefit; he says in fact: “If you in turn had only understood on this day the message of peace!” All of us are born as sons of anger and enemies of God, and God gives us the time of the earthly life so that we can find peace, and we can achieve his grace and finally we can obtain his glory. But unfortunately we do not worry at all about this; on the contrary, falling back every day into sin, we become always more the enemies of God. And this happens because neither the fruit of the grace of God nor the fruit of sin, which consists in the eternal damnation is visible to our eyes.

Yet, O Christian, we know for certain that the heaven and the earth will pass away, but the words of Christ cannot pass. Christ threatens Jerusalem with its extreme ruin and foretells its destruction by its enemies, and this happens. To us he foretells the eternal damnation, if we do not dispose ourselves to penance: “Convert, because the kingdom of heaven is near; if you do not convert you will all perish in the same way” (Mt. 4: 17; Lk. 13: 5), as the sinners who died in the flood or in the fire of Pentapolis. And we, what should we do? Should we dispose ourselves in penance for our sins, or rather do we add more serious sins to the ones we have already committed? How deplorable is our blindness!

When Jesus was near Jerusalem, “at the sight of the city he cried”, since it had not recognised the time of his visit (cfr. Lk. 19: 41, 44). In his merciful goodness the Lord has visited us in order to illuminate us: “in order to give to his people the knowledge of salvation in the remission of its sins” (Lk. 1: 77); he has visited us in order to save us from our sins: to “grant us, freed from the hands of our enemies, the possibility of serving him without fear, in holiness and justice in his presence, all the days of our life” (Lk. 1: 74- 75). But of grace, brothers, if we want to act in this way, we must always remember our end. Then, keeping our death always in front of us, we will know how to understand the vanity of the world and to direct our steps on the way of holiness and justice.

**Responsorial.** *Jer. 15: 5-6; Lk. 19: 42*

**R:** Who will have pity on you, Jerusalem, who will be sorry for you? Who will turn to ask you how you are? \* You have repelled me, says the Lord.

**V:** If only you had also understood, on this day, the way of peace! But it has been hidden from your eyes.

**R:** You have repelled me, says the Lord.

## CYCLE 2

### **First Reading** *Job 11: 1 –20*

*Discourse of Zophar: do you believe that you can scrutinize the depths of God*

Then Zophar the Na'amathite answered: "Should a multitude of words go unanswered, and a man full of talk be vindicated? Should your babble silence men, and when you mock, shall no one shame you? For you say, 'My doctrine is pure, and I am clean in God's eyes'. But oh, that God would speak, and open his lips to you, and that he would tell you the secrets of wisdom! For he is manifold in understanding. Know then that God exacts of you less than your guilt deserves. Can you find out the deep things of God? Can you find out the limit of the Almighty? It is higher than heaven -- what can you do? Deeper than Sheol -- what can you know? Its measure is longer than the earth, and broader than the sea. If he passes through, and imprisons, and calls to judgment, who can hinder him? For he knows worthless men; when he sees iniquity, will he not consider it?

But a stupid man will receive understanding when a wild ass's colt is born a man. If you set your heart aright, you will stretch out your hands toward him. If iniquity is in your hand, put it far away, and let not wickedness dwell in your tents. Surely then you will lift up your face without blemish; you will be secure, and will not fear. You will forget your misery; you will remember it as waters that have passed away. And your life will be brighter than the noonday; its darkness will be like the morning. And you will have confidence, because there is hope; you will be protected and take your rest in safety. You will lie down, and none will make you afraid; many will entreat your favour.

But the eyes of the wicked will fail; all way of escape will be lost to them, and their hope is to breathe their last."

**Responsorial** *Cf. 2 Cor. 4: 8, 9, 10*

**R:** We are in difficulties, but not crushed; we see no answer to our problems, but we do not despair; \* we suffer persecutions, but we are not lost.

**V:** We always carry in our body the death of Christ, so that also his life may be manifested in us:

**R:** we suffer persecutions, but we are not lost.

**Second Reading** *Book 10: 7 – 8, 10*

*Multiple is the law of God*

**A reading from the “Commentary on the book of Job” of St. Gregory the Great, pope**

What should the ‘law’ of God be taken to mean, if not charity? By charity we learn inwardly how the commandments of life are to be put into practice. Concerning this law the voice of Truth has said, ‘This is my commandment, that you love one another’. Concerning it Paul says, ‘Love is the fulfilment of the law’. Again, he says ‘Bear one another’s burdens, and so fulfil the law of Christ’. What can the law of Christ be more rightly understood to mean, than charity? And we truly fulfil his law when, for the principle of love, we bear the burdens of our brethren.

Now this same law is called ‘manifold’: for charity, full of eager solicitude, expands into all acts of virtue. Truly, it begins with only two precepts, but it reaches out into a countless number.

Paul rightly calculates the multiplicity of this same law in the words, ‘Love is patient and kind; love is not jealous or arrogant; it does nothing wrong, it is not covetous. Love does not insist on its own way; it is not irritable or resentful; it does not rejoice at wrong but rejoices in the right’.

Yes, love is ‘patient’, because she bears with equanimity the ills which befall her. She is ‘kind’ in that she renders good for evil with a bounteous hand. She is not ‘jealous’, for since she covets nothing in this present life, it does not enter her mind to envy earthly successes. She is not ‘arrogant’, for while she does eagerly desire inner reward, she does not give herself airs on the grounds of exterior good things. She ‘does nothing wrong’, for in so far

as she spreads herself in the love of God and neighbour alone, she is a stranger to whatever is at variance with the rule of right.

She is not 'covetous', for while she is warmly diligent about her own concerns, she never covets what belongs to others at all. 'Love does not insist on its own way', for all that she holds in this life, with a transitory ownership, she disregards, as though it were another's; for she is well aware that nothing belongs to her but that which will be hers for ever. She 'is not irritable', for even when prompted by wrongs she never excites herself to any motions of revenge, and she looks to the hereafter for greater rewards for her great labours. She is not 'resentful', for, basing the soul in love of purity, while plucking up all hatred by the roots, she cannot harbour in the mind anything that pollutes.

She 'does not rejoice at wrong', for, since she yearns towards all men with love alone, she does not triumph even in the ruin of those who are against her; but she does 'rejoice in the right', for loving others she is filled with joy as if at the growth of her own proficiency. Thus is this 'law of God' manifold.

**Responsorial** *Rom 13: 8, 10; Gal 5: 4*

**R:** Leave no claim outstanding against you, except that of mutual love. He who loves his neighbour has satisfied every claim of the law. \* The whole law is summed up in love.

**V:** The whole law can be summed up in a single commandment. Love your neighbour as yourself.

**R:** The whole law is summed up in love.

YEAR A

**Gospel** *Mt. 13: 24-43*

He put before them another parable: "The kingdom of heaven may be compared to someone who sowed good seed in his field; but while everybody was asleep, an enemy came and sowed weeds among the wheat, and then went away. So when the plants came up and bore grain, then the weeds appeared as well. And the slaves of the householder came and said to him, 'Master, did you not sow good seed in your field? Where, then, did these weeds come from?' He answered, 'An enemy has done this.' The

slaves said to him, 'Then do you want us to go and gather them?' But he replied, 'No; for in gathering the weeds you would uproot the wheat along with them. Let both of them grow together until the harvest; and at harvest time I will tell the reapers, Collect the weeds first and bind them in bundles to be burned, but gather the wheat into my barn.'

He put before them another parable: "The kingdom of heaven is like a mustard seed that someone took and sowed in his field; it is the smallest of all the seeds, but when it has grown it is the greatest of shrubs and becomes a tree, so that the birds of the air come and make nests in its branches."

He told them another parable: "The kingdom of heaven is like yeast that a woman took and mixed in with three measures of flour until all of it was leavened." Jesus told the crowds all these things in parables; without a parable he told them nothing. This was to fulfil what had been spoken through the prophet: "I will open my mouth to speak in parables; I will proclaim what has been hidden from the foundation of the world."

Then he left the crowds and went into the house. And his disciples approached him, saying, "Explain to us the parable of the weeds of the field." He answered, "The one who sows the good seed is the Son of Man; the field is the world, and the good seed are the children of the kingdom; the weeds are the children of the evil one, and the enemy who sowed them is the devil; the harvest is the end of the age, and the reapers are angels. Just as the weeds are collected and burned up with fire, so will it be at the end of the age. The Son of Man will send his angels, and they will collect out of his kingdom all causes of sin and all evildoers, and they will throw them into the furnace of fire, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth. Then the righteous will shine like the sun in the kingdom of their Father. Let anyone with ears listen!

### **Third Reading** *Hom. 46, 2-3*

*As the leaven ferments the whole flour, so also you will convert the whole world*

### **A reading from the "Homilies on Matthew" of St. John Chrysostom, bishop**

"The kingdom of heaven can be compared to the yeast, that a woman took and mixed with three measures of flour till it was leavened all through" (Mt. 13: 33). As the yeast leavens with its strength all the flour, so

also will you convert the whole world. He does not say: how can twelve of us transform such a great multitude? Already the fact itself that you do not avoid being mixed with the crowd makes your virtue immensely splendid. As the yeast ferments the mass when it is kneaded with the flour, and it is kneaded exactly in order to mix itself, so he does not say simply "taken", but "kneaded": in fact you also, kneaded and united with your adversaries, you overcome them. The leaven is hidden in the mass, but is not lost, on the contrary slowly it communicates its strength to the mass: the same happens with the preaching. You must not fear if I have pre-announced many tribulations for you: thus in fact you will become light and you will be able to overcome everything.

It is Christ who gives to the yeast its virtue. For this he mixes those who believe in him with the multitude, in order to allow a reciprocal exchange of the experience of him. No one should worry about his smallness. Great is the strength of the preaching; and that which has been leavened, will become in its turn leaven.

Like a spark that falls on wood burns and transforms it into fire, which in its turn invades others, so also it is with the preaching. Yet I do not give the example of the fire, but of the yeast. Why? Because in the fire not everything proceeds from the fire, but also from the wood that burns; the yeast instead ferments everything uniquely through its intrinsic strength. Now if twelve men have fermented the whole earth, think how great is our wickedness if, even though being many, we are not capable of converting those who remain, while we should be capable of fermenting thousands of worlds. But – I would say – those were apostles. And what does this mean? Were they not in the same condition as you? Did they not live in the cities? Did they not live the same vicissitudes of their fellow citizens? Did they not exercise a trade? Were they perhaps angels? Had they perhaps descended from heaven? However they did miracles, you say. For how long will we use the pretext of their miracles in order to cover our sloth? What sign did John accomplish, that attracted to him so many cities? No miracle: listen in fact to the evangelist who says: "John gave no signs" (Jn. 10: 41).

And the same Christ, giving his norms to the disciples, perhaps told his disciples to accomplish miracles in order to make themselves seen by men? Not at all, on the contrary: "So shall your light shine forth in front of men, so that seeing your good deeds they may give glory to your Father who is in heaven" (Mt. 5: 16). Do you see how it is necessary that the life is good and



full of good works? “From their fruit you will recognise them” (Mt. 7: 16), says the Lord.

**Responsorial** *1 Cor. 2: 4-5; 1: 21*

**R:** My word and my message is not based on persuasive discourses of wisdom, but on the manifestation of the Spirit and on his power, \* so that your faith would not be founded on human wisdom, but on the power of God.

**V:** It was God’s wisdom that human wisdom should not know God, it was because God wanted to save those who have faith through the foolishness of the message that we preach,

**R:** so that your faith would not be founded on human wisdom, but on the power of God.

YEAR B

**Gospel** *Mk. 6: 30-34*

The apostles gathered around Jesus, and told him all that they had done and taught. He said to them, "Come away to a deserted place all by yourselves and rest a while." For many were coming and going, and they had no leisure even to eat. And they went away in the boat to a deserted place by themselves.

Now many saw them going and recognized them, and they hurried there on foot from all the towns and arrived ahead of them. As he went ashore, he saw a great crowd; and he had compassion for them, because they were like sheep without a shepherd; and he began to teach them many things.

**Third Reading** *Hom. 26, 2*

*Christ did not despise what he saw*

**A reading from the “Homilies” of St. Basil of Seleucia, bishop**

With reason Christ, being shepherd, exclaimed: “I am the good shepherd” (Jn. 10: 11). “I myself will bind the wounded sheep and I will cure those who are sick, I will go in search of the lost sheep and I will lead back to the sheepfold the one that is lost” (Ez. 34: 16). I have seen the flock of the Israelites in prey to evil, I have seen them end up in the dwelling of the demons, torn to pieces by these as by wolves. And I have not despised what I have seen.

In fact, I am the good shepherd: not the Pharisees who are jealous of the sheep, nor those who consider the benefits conferred on the flock as a loss to themselves, nor those who afflict themselves because the others are freed from evil and are pained because of the sicknesses healed. The dead rise, and the Pharisee cries, the paralytic is healed and the scribes lament; to the blind man the sight is given back and the priests are angry; the leper is healed and the priests protest. O proud shepherds of the miserable flock, who delight in its misfortune!

“I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd offers his life for the sheep”(Jn.10: 11).

The shepherd lets himself be led to death like a lamb for his flock: he does not refuse to die, he does not protest, he does not attack the executioners. His passion was not necessary, but he accepted death voluntarily for the sheep: “I have the power to offer my life and the power to take it up again” (Jn. 10: 17, 18). He expiates the evil with suffering and remedies death with his death; he destroys the sepulchre with his sepulchre, he tears out the nails and knocks down the foundations of hell. Death for a long time held the power, until Christ had not struck it; for a long time the tombs were full and the prison was closed, until the Shepherd, releasing them, brought the propitious announcement of the liberation to the imprisoned sheep. He was seen in the underworld giving the signal of the return, the sign that from the sepulchre recalled them to a new life.

“The good shepherd offers his life for the sheep” (Jn. 10: 11).

Through this way he prepared to conclude a friendship with the sheep.

Christ, then, loves those who welcome his voice with love.

As a shepherd, he knows how to separate the goats from the sheep. “Come, blessed of my Father, receive in inheritance the kingdom prepared for you from the foundations of the world” (Mt. 25: 34).

What does this call reward? “Because I was hungry and you gave me to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me to drink, I was a stranger and you

welcomed me into your house” (Mt. 25: 35).

In fact that which you offered to my disciples, you got from me. I for them am naked, stranger, wanderer and poor: for them is the gift, but mine is the grace. I suffer in their supplication.

Christ knows how to be overcome by the hands and by the gifts of the poor, he knows that through a small gift long torments are remitted. Let us extinguish the fire with mercy, practising reciprocal love we cast far away from us the threats that are turned against us, let us open in turn our hearts to mercy, having received ourselves the grace from God in Christ, to whom be glory and power forever and ever. Amen.

**Responsorial** *1 Jn. 3: 16; Rm. 5: 7, 8*

**R:** From this have we known love: He has given his life for us; \* therefore we too must give our lives for the brothers.

**V:** It is not easy to die even for a good man. But what proves that God loves us is that Christ died for us while we were still sinners;

**R:** therefore we too must give our lives for the brothers.

YEAR C

**Gospel** *Lk. 10: 38-42*

Now as they went on their way, he entered a certain village, where a woman named Martha welcomed him into her home. She had a sister named Mary, who sat at the Lord's feet and listened to what he was saying. But Martha was distracted by her many tasks; so she came to him and asked, "Lord, do you not care that my sister has left me to do all the work by myself? Tell her then to help me." But the Lord answered her, "Martha, Martha, you are worried and distracted by many things; there is need of only one thing. Mary has chosen the better part, which will not be taken away from her."

**Third Reading** *Book 2, Hom. 2, 8-9*

*The active life and the life of contemplation*

**A reading from the “Homilies on Ezekiel” of St. Gregory the Great, pope**

To give bread to the hungry, to teach wisdom to the one who does not know it, to correct the wanderer and to recall to the way of humility the proud; to take care of the sick, to dispense that which can be of service to the individuals and to whoever, and to provide the necessary to those who have been entrusted to us, is active life. It is instead contemplative life to keep with all the heart the love of God and of the neighbour, but abstaining oneself from the exterior activity and letting oneself be invaded uniquely by the desire of the Creator, in a way that he does not have taste for any other work, but rather, neglecting all other worries, the heart burns with the desire of seeing the face of its Creator, it bears with pain the weight of the corruptible flesh and aspires with all of itself to unite itself to the acclaiming choirs of the angels, to the citizens of heaven, and to enjoy eternally of the infinite contemplation of God.

Martha and Mary symbolise well these two states of life: the first in fact worried herself in doing many things, the other instead sat at the feet of the Lord in order to listen to his words. Since Martha complained about her sister because she neglected to help her, the Lord answered her: “Martha, Martha, you worry and fret for many things, but only one thing is necessary: Mary has chosen the better part, and it will not be taken away from her” (Lk. 10: 41. 42). The part of Martha is not blamed, but that of Mary is praised. He does not say in fact that Mary had chosen the good part, but the better part, in order to indicate that also the part of Martha was good.

That then the part of Mary is better, is underlined when he says: “and it will not be taken away from her”. The active life in fact finishes with death, since who will give his bread to the hungry, in his eternal life, where no one is hungry? And who will give to drink to the thirsty there where no one is thirsty? Who will bury the dead there where no one dies? Therefore, while the active life will finish in this world, the contemplative one begins here and reaches its perfection in the heavenly homeland, since the fire of love that has begun and burns down here will blaze even more at the sight of the beloved. The contemplative life therefore is never taken away, because, once the light of this present world is put off, it becomes perfect.

**Responsorial** *Wis. 3: 14, 15; Mt. 5: 8*

**R:** He will receive a more desirable part in the temple of the Lord \* because the fruit of good works is glorious.

**V:** Blessed are the pure in heart, because they will see God.

**R:** because the fruit of good works is glorious.

# MONDAY

## CYCLE 1

**First Reading** *2 Sam. 18: 6 – 17, 24- 19: 4*

*Death of Absalom and sorrow of David*

So the army went out into the field against Israel; and the battle was fought in the forest of E'phraim. And the men of Israel were defeated there by the servants of David, and the slaughter there was great on that day, twenty thousand men. The battle spread over the face of all the country; and the forest devoured more people that day than the sword. And Ab'salom chanced to meet the servants of David. Ab'salom was riding upon his mule, and the mule went under the thick branches of a great oak, and his head caught fast in the oak, and he was left hanging between heaven and earth, while the mule that was under him went on.

And a certain man saw it, and told Jo'ab, "Behold, I saw Ab'salom hanging in an oak." Jo'ab said to the man who told him, "What, you saw him! Why then did you not strike him there to the ground? I would have been glad to give you ten pieces of silver and a girdle." But the man said to Jo'ab, "Even if I felt in my hand the weight of a thousand pieces of silver, I would not put forth my hand against the king's son; for in our hearing the king commanded you and Abi'shai and It'tai, 'For my sake protect the young man Ab'salom.' On the other hand, if I had dealt treacherously against his life (and there is nothing hidden from the king), then you yourself would have stood aloof."

Jo'ab said, "I will not waste time like this with you." And he took three darts in his hand, and thrust them into the heart of Ab'salom, while he was still alive in the oak. And ten young men, Jo'ab's armour-bearers, surrounded Ab'salom and struck him, and killed him. Then Jo'ab blew the trumpet, and the troops came back from pursuing Israel; for Jo'ab restrained them. And they took Ab'salom, and threw him into a great pit in the forest, and raised over him a very great heap of stones; and all Israel fled every one to his own home.

Now David was sitting between the two gates; and the watchman went up to the roof of the gate by the wall, and when he lifted up his eyes and looked, he saw a man running alone. And the watchman called out and told

the king. And the king said, "If he is alone, there are tidings in his mouth." And he came apace, and drew near. And the watchman saw another man running; and the watchman called to the gate and said, "See, another man running alone!" The king said, "He also brings tidings." And the watchman said, "I think the running of the foremost is like the running of Ahi'ma-az the son of Zadok." And the king said, "He is a good man, and comes with good tidings."

Then Ahi'ma-az cried out to the king, "All is well." And he bowed before the king with his face to the earth, and said, "Blessed be the LORD your God, who has delivered up the men who raised their hand against my lord the king." And the king said, "Is it well with the young man Ab'salom?" Ahi'ma-az answered, "When Jo'ab sent your servant, I saw a great tumult, but I do not know what it was." And the king said, "Turn aside, and stand here." So he turned aside, and stood still.

And behold, the Cushite came; and the Cushite said, "Good tidings for my lord the king! For the LORD has delivered you this day from the power of all who rose up against you." The king said to the Cushite, "Is it well with the young man Ab'salom?" And the Cushite answered, "May the enemies of my lord the king, and all who rise up against you for evil, be like that young man."

And the king was deeply moved, and went up to the chamber over the gate, and wept; and as he went, he said, "O my son Ab'salom, my son, my son Ab'salom! Would I had died instead of you, O Ab'salom, my son, my son!"

It was told Jo'ab, "Behold, the king is weeping and mourning for Ab'salom." So the victory that day was turned into mourning for all the people; for the people heard that day, "The king is grieving for his son." And the people stole into the city that day as people steal in who are ashamed when they flee in battle. The king covered his face, and the king cried with a loud voice, "O my son Ab'salom, O Ab'salom, my son, my son!"

**Responsorial** *Cfr. Ps. 54: 13, 14, 15; 40: 10; 2 Sam. 19: 1*

**R:** If an enemy had insulted me, I would have borne it; but it is you, my companion, my friend and the one in whom I confided! \* A loving bond united us, and you have raised your heel against me.

**V:** The king shivered, he went up to the top floor and cried: and he said in tears:

**R:** A loving bond united us, and you have raised your heel against me.

**Second Reading** *Ps. 32: 29*

*Those who find themselves outside, if they want or not, are our brothers*

**A reading from the “Commentary on the psalms” of St. Augustine, bishop**

My brothers, we appeal to you above all to show charity, not only towards one another, but also to those who are outside the fold, whether they are still pagans, not yet believing in Christ, or separated from us, confessing the same head as we do, but separated from the body. My friends, let us grieve for them as our brothers. Whether they like it or not, they are our brothers, and they will only cease to be our brothers if they cease to say ‘Our Father’.

The prophet said of certain people: ‘To those who say to you. ‘You are not our brothers’, say, ‘You are our brothers’. Ask yourselves whom he could have meant- surely not the pagans? No, for according to the scriptures and in the normal usage of the Church we do not call them our brothers. Surely it was not the Jews, who did not believe in Christ?

Read the apostle, and observe that when he says ‘brothers’ without any qualification he means only Christians: ‘Why do you pass judgement on your brother? Or you, why do you despise your brother?’ and he says in another place: ‘You yourselves wrong and defraud, and that even your brothers’.

Therefore those who say, ‘You are not our brothers’, are calling us pagans. For this reason they want to re-baptise us, saying that we do not possess what they confer. From this follows their error of denying that we are their brothers. But why did the prophet tell us, ‘Say to them: You are our brothers’, if not because we recognise in them what we do not repeat. They, by not recognising our baptism, deny that we are their brothers; but we, by not repeating theirs, and acknowledging it as our own, say to them: ‘You are our brothers’.

They may say: ‘Why do you seek us out, why do you want us?’ Let our reply be: ‘You are our brothers’. They may say: ‘Go away, we have no concern with you’. We certainly have concern with you, we shall answer:



we confess one Christ, we ought to be joined in a single body under one head.

It is time for us to show them great love and abundant compassion by beseeching God to bring them to their senses, to restore them to right reason so that they can see that they have nothing at all which they can urge against the truth. They have nothing left except the weakness of animosity that is all the feebler the stronger it thinks itself to be. We therefore appeal to you, my brothers, for the sake of charity itself whose milk feeds us and whose bread strengthens us, for the sake of Christ our Lord and his gentleness, we appeal to you on behalf of the weak, the worldly-wise, the sensual and the carnal, and yet, on behalf of our brothers. They celebrate the same sacraments, though not with us, but still the same; they reply with the same Amen, though not with us, but it is still the same. Pour out all your love to God on their behalf.

**Responsorial** *Cf. Ep. 4: 1, 3-4*

**R:** I implore you, for the sake of the Lord, to lead a life worthy of your vocation. \* Do all you can to preserve the unity of the Spirit, in the bond of peace.

**V:** There is one Body, one Spirit, just as you were all called into one and the same hope when you were called.

**R:** Do all you can to preserve the unity of the Spirit, in the bond of peace.

CYCLE 2

**First Reading** *Job 12: 1 – 25*

*The answer of Job: God has every living being in His hand. He dominates human wisdom*

Then Job answered: "No doubt you are the people, and wisdom will die with you. But I have understanding as well as you; I am not inferior to you.

Who does not know such things as these? I am a laughingstock to my friends; I, who called upon God and he answered me, a just and blameless man, am a laughingstock. In the thought of one who is at ease there is contempt for misfortune; it is ready for those whose feet slip. The tents of robbers are at peace, and those who provoke God are secure, who bring their god in their hand.

"But ask the beasts, and they will teach you; the birds of the air, and they will tell you; or the plants of the earth, and they will teach you; and the fish of the sea will declare to you. Who among all these does not know that the hand of the LORD has done this? In his hand is the life of every living thing and the breath of all mankind. Does not the ear try words as the palate tastes food? Wisdom is with the aged, and understanding in length of days.

"With God are wisdom and might; he has counsel and understanding. If he tears down, none can rebuild; if he shuts a man in, none can open. If he withholds the waters, they dry up; if he sends them out, they overwhelm the land. With him are strength and wisdom; the deceived and the deceiver are his. He leads counsellors away stripped, and judges he makes fools. He looses the bonds of kings, and binds a waistcloth on their loins. He leads priests away stripped, and overthrows the mighty. He deprives of speech those who are trusted, and takes away the discernment of the elders. He pours contempt on princes, and looses the belt of the strong.

He uncovers the deeps out of darkness, and brings deep darkness to light. He makes nations great, and he destroys them: he enlarges nations, and leads them away. He takes away understanding from the chiefs of the people of the earth, and makes them wander in a pathless waste. They grope in the dark without light; and he makes them stagger like a drunken man.

**Responsorial** *Cf. Job 12: 13, 14; 23: 13*

**R:** Wisdom and strength resides in God, to him belongs council and prudence. \* If he destroys, you cannot rebuild; if he imprisons, you cannot liberate.

**V:** He is the only One: if he chooses, who can make him change? What he wants, he does.

**R:** If he destroys, you cannot rebuild; if he imprisons, you cannot liberate.

## **Second Reading Book 10: 47 – 48**

### *The interior testimony*

## **A reading from the “Commentary on the book of Job” of St. Gregory the Great, pope**

‘He who is mocked by his neighbour, as I am, will call upon God and he will answer him’.

Often, the frail mind, acclaimed for its good actions by the breath of human regard, dissipates itself in outward delights, so that it lays aside what it inwardly desires and is willing to lie loosely in the external things to which it hearkens. It delights not so much in becoming, as in being called, blessed; and because it longs for the words of applause, it ceases to strive after what it had begun to be; and so, the very means through which it appeared to be commendable in God, sever it from God.

But sometimes it perseveres in good works with a constant heart, and yet is pushed hard by the scoffing of men; it does admirable deeds, and gets only abuse; and he who might have been encouraged to come out of himself by commendation, is repulsed by insults and returns back again into himself. He establishes himself the more firmly in God, as he finds no place else where he may rest in peace: for all his hope is fixed in his creator. Amidst ridicule and abuse, he implores only the interior witness. His soul in distress becomes God’s neighbour, in proportion as he is a stranger to the favour of man’s esteem. So he pours himself out in prayer and, hard-pressed from without, is refined with a more perfect purity to enter more deeply into all that is interior. Therefore, it is well said at this time, he who is mocked by his neighbour as I am, will call upon God and he will answer him. For though the wicked may reproach the soul of the good, yet the good are showing them whom to seek as witness of their actions. And while the soul of the good strengthens itself, with compunction, in prayer, it is united within itself in the hearing of the Most High, in the very act that severs it from the approval of men outside itself.

But we should note how thoughtfully are inserted the words ‘as I am’. For there are some men who are downcast at the ridicule of their fellowmen; and yet they are not the kind of men to be heard by the ears of God. For when they are ridiculed because of their sins, surely they gain no virtuous merit from their mocking.

‘For the upright man’s simplicity is laughed to scorn’. **It is the wisdom of this world to conceal one’s feelings with pretence, to veil the sense with words; to show things that are false as true, and to make out as fallacious what is true.**

But on the other hand it is the wisdom of the righteous to pretend nothing in show, to discover the meaning by words; to love the truth as it is, to avoid falsehood; to set forth good deeds freely, to bear evil more gladly than to do it; to seek no revenge of a wrong, to count ill-repute as a gain for the truth’s sake, but this simplicity of the righteous is laughed to scorn, because the goodness of purity is taken for folly by the wise men of this world. For doubtless everything that is done from innocence is counted foolish by them, and whatever truth sanctions in practice sounds weak to carnal wisdom.

**Responsorial.** *Ps. 118: 104- 105; Jn. 6: 68*

**R:** I hate the paths of falsehood. \* Your word is a lamp for my steps, and a light for my path.

**V:** Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the message of eternal life.

**R:** Your word is a lamp for my steps, and a light for my path.

**Gospel.** *Mt. 12. 38 – 42*

*The queen of the south will stand up and judge this generation.*

**A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.**

Then some of the scribes and Pharisees said to him, "Teacher, we wish to see a sign from you." But he answered them, "An evil and adulterous generation seeks for a sign; but no sign shall be given to it except the sign of the prophet Jonah. For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the whale, so will the Son of man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth. The men of Nin'evah will arise at the judgment with this generation and condemn it; for they repented at the preaching of Jonah, and behold, something greater than Jonah is here. The queen of the South will arise at the judgment with this generation and condemn it; for she came from the ends of the earth to hear the wisdom of Solomon, and behold, something greater than Solomon is here.

## TUESDAY

### CYCLE 1

**First Reading.** *2 Sam. 24: 1 – 4, 10 – 18, 24b – 25*

*The census of the people and the erection of the altar.*

**A reading from the second book of Samuel.**

Again the anger of the LORD was kindled against Israel, and he incited David against them, saying, "Go, number Israel and Judah."

So the king said to Jo'ab and the commanders of the army, who were with him, "Go through all the tribes of Israel, from Dan to Beer-sheba, and number the people, that I may know the number of the people." But Jo'ab said to the king, "May the LORD your God add to the people a hundred times as many as they are, while the eyes of my lord the king still see it; but why does my lord the king delight in this thing?" But the king's word prevailed against Jo'ab and the commanders of the army. So Jo'ab and the commanders of the army went out from the presence of the king to number the people of Israel.

But David's heart smote him after he had numbered the people. And David said to the LORD, "I have sinned greatly in what I have done. But now, O LORD, I pray you, take away the iniquity of your servant; for I have done very foolishly."

And when David arose in the morning, the word of the LORD came to the prophet Gad, David's seer, saying, "Go and say to David, 'Thus says the LORD, Three things I offer you; choose one of them, that I may do it to you.' So Gad came to David and told him, and said to him, "Shall three years of famine come to you in your land? Or will you flee three months before your foes while they pursue you? Or shall there be three days' pestilence in your land? Now consider, and decide what answer I shall return to him who sent me."

Then David said to Gad, "I am in great distress; let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is great; but let me not fall into the hand of man." So the LORD sent a pestilence upon Israel from the morning until the appointed time; and there died of the people from Dan to Beer-sheba seventy thousand men. And when the angel stretched forth his hand toward Jerusalem to destroy it, the LORD repented of the evil, and said to the angel

who was working destruction among the people, "It is enough; now stay your hand." And the angel of the LORD was by the threshing floor of Arau'nah the Jeb'usite. Then David spoke to the LORD when he saw the angel who was smiting the people, and said, "Lo, I have sinned, and I have done wickedly; but these sheep, what have they done? Let your hand, I pray you, be against me and against my father's house."

And Gad came that day to David, and said to him, "Go up, rear an altar to the LORD on the threshing floor of Arau'nah the Jeb'usite." But the king said to Arau'nah, "No, but I will buy it of you for a price; I will not offer burnt offerings to the LORD my God which cost me nothing." So David bought the threshing floor and the oxen for fifty shekels of silver. And David built there an altar to the LORD, and offered burnt offerings and peace offerings. So the LORD heeded supplications for the land, and the plague was averted from Israel.

**Responsorial.** *Cfr. Jdt. 9: 18 Vulg.; 1 Chr. 21: 15; 2 Sam. 24: 17*

**R:** Remember, Lord, your covenant; command the punishing angel: Hold your hand, \* do not destroy the earth, do not exterminate all the living.

**V:** I have sinned and I have committed evil; but they what have they done? Lord, let your hand not strike your people;

**R:** do not destroy the earth, do not exterminate all the living.

**Second Reading.** *C. 9, 10, 14*

*The Eucharist.*

**A reading from the "Doctrine of the twelve apostles"**

Now concerning the Thanksgiving (Eucharist), thus give thanks. First, concerning the cup: We thank you, our Father, for the holy vine of David your servant, which You made known to us through Jesus your Servant; to you be glory for ever.

And concerning the broken bread: We thank you, our Father, for the life and knowledge which you made known to us through Jesus your Servant; to you be the glory for ever. Even as this broken bread was scattered over the hills, and was gathered together and became one, so let your Church be gathered together from the ends of the earth into your kingdom; for yours is the glory and the power through Jesus Christ for ever.

But let no one eat or drink of your Thanksgiving (Eucharist), but they who have been baptized into the name of the Lord; for concerning this also the Lord has said, give not that which is holy to the dogs.

But after you are filled, thus give thanks: We thank you, Holy Father, for your holy name which you did cause to dwell in our hearts, and for the knowledge and faith and immortality, which you made known to us through Jesus your Servant; to you be the glory for ever.

You, almighty Master, did create all things for your name's sake; you gave food and drink to men for enjoyment, that they might give thanks to you; but to us you did freely give spiritual food and drink and life eternal through your Servant. Before all things we thank you that you are mighty; to you be the glory forever.

Remember, Lord, your Church, to deliver it from all evil and to make it perfect in your love, and gather it from the four winds, sanctified for your kingdom which you have prepared for it; for yours is the power and the glory for ever.

Let grace come, and let this world pass away. Hosanna to the God (Son) of David! **If any one is holy, let him come; if any one is not so, let him repent.** Maranatha. Amen.

But permit the prophets to make Thanksgiving as much as they desire. But every Lord's day do you gather yourselves together, and break bread, and give thanksgiving after having confessed your transgressions, that your sacrifice may be pure. But let no one that is at variance with his fellow come together with you, until they are reconciled, that your sacrifice may not be profaned. For this is what the Lord said: In every place and time offer to me **a pure sacrifice**; for I am a great King, says the Lord, and my name is wonderful among the nations.

**Responsorial.** *1 Cor. 10: 16-17*

**R:** Is not the chalice that we bless, the communion with the blood of Christ?

\* Is not the bread that we break the communion with the body of Christ?

**V:** Since there is only one bread we, though being many, are only one body: all of us in fact participate in one unique bread.

**R:** Is not the bread that we break the communion with the body of Christ?

**First Reading.** *Jb. 13: 13 – 14: 6*

*Job appeals to the judgement of God.*

**A reading from the book of Job.**

"Let me have silence, and I will speak, and let come on me what may. I will take my flesh in my teeth, and put my life in my hand. Behold, he will slay me; I have no hope; yet I will defend my ways to his face. This will be my salvation: that a godless man shall not come before him. Listen carefully to my words, and let my declaration be in your ears. Behold, I have prepared my case; I know that I shall be vindicated. Who is there that will contend with me? For then I would be silent and die. Only grant two things to me, then I will not hide myself from your face: withdraw your hand far from me, and let not dread of you terrify me. Then call, and I will answer; or let me speak, and do you reply to me. How many are my iniquities and my sins? Make me know my transgression and my sin. Why do you hide your face, and count me as your enemy? Will you frighten a driven leaf and pursue dry chaff? For you write bitter things against me, and make me inherit the iniquities of my youth. You put my feet in the stocks, and watch all my paths; you set a bound to the soles of my feet. Man wastes away like a rotten thing, like a garment that is moth-eaten.

"Man that is born of a woman is of few days, and full of trouble. He comes forth like a flower, and withers; he flees like a shadow, and continues not. And do you open your eyes upon such a one and bring him into judgment with you? Who can bring a clean thing out of an unclean? There is not one. Since his days are determined, and the number of his months is with you, and you have appointed his bounds that he cannot pass, look away from him, and desist, that he may enjoy, like a hireling, his day.

**Responsorial.** *Cfr. Jb. 13: 20, 21; Jer. 10: 24*

**R:** Do not remove me from your presence, Lord, turn away from me the punishment of your hand \* and your terror will not terrify me anymore.

**V:** Correct me, Lord, but with a just measure, not according to your anger, because I will faint,

**R:** and your terror will not terrify me anymore.



**Second Reading. *Treatise 15: 2***

*Job prefigured Christ.*

**A reading from the “Treatise” of St. Zeno of Verona, bishop.**

For as much as we can understand, dearly beloved, Job prefigured Christ. The comparison will demonstrate the exactness of this statement. Job has been declared just by God and Christ is justice itself. From him, as from a spring, all those who are blessed drink. Of him in fact it is said: The sun of justice will rise for you” (Mal. 3: 20). Job is said to be a truthful man. Now the Lord is truth itself. In the Gospel he has said: “I am the way and the truth” (Jn. 14: 6). Job was rich. And who is richer than the Lord? All the rich are his servants and the whole earth with all the things that are contained in it belong to him, as the great prophet David attests: “The Lord’s is the earth and all that it contains, the universe and all its inhabitants” (Ps. 23: 1). Three times Job has been tempted by the devil. In the same way three times, as the evangelist says, the devil tried to tempt the Lord.

Job was deprived of all the riches that he possessed, the Lord also, for love of us, deprived himself of all the heavenly goods and made himself poor, in order to make us rich. The devil in his rage killed the sons of Job. The Pharisaic people too in their mad hate killed the prophets, sons of the Lord.

Job was covered with wounds. The Lord also, assuming our flesh, covered himself with the filth and iniquity of the whole human race.

The wife of Job exhorted him to curse. So also the synagogue tried to push the Lord to follow the false traditions of the Pharisees.

Job was insulted by his friends and the Lord also was insulted by his priests, by those who should have honoured him.

Job sat upon a dunghill full of worms. The Lord also moved about on the real dunghill of the filth of this world amidst men seething with all manner of vices and lusts, which are the real worms.

Job recovered both his health and his possessions. But the Lord at his resurrection held out to those who believe in him not merely health but immortality, and took back to himself dominion over all nature as he himself bears witness when he says, ‘All things have been delivered to me by my Father’. Job begot new sons to replace those he had lost. The Lord too begot holy sons, the apostles, in place of the prophets. Job blessed,

rested in peace. But the Lord remains blessed forever before all ages, from all ages and throughout all ages.

**Responsorial.** *Cfr. Heb. 12: 1-2,; 2 Cor. 6: 4-5*

**R:** We should keep running steadily in the race we have started. \* Let us not lose sight of Jesus, who leads us in our faith and brings it to perfection.

**V:** We prove ourselves by great fortitude in times of suffering, in times of hardship and distress, when we are flogged or sent to prison.

**R:** Let us not lose sight of Jesus, who leads us in our faith and brings it to perfection.

**Gospel.** *Mt. 12: 46 – 50*

*Stretching out His hand to the disciples He said: Here are my mother and brothers.*

**A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.**

While he was still speaking to the people, behold, his mother and his brothers stood outside, asking to speak to him. But he replied to the man who told him, "Who is my mother, and who are my brothers?" And stretching out his hand toward his disciples, he said, "Here are my mother and my brothers! For **whoever does the will of my Father in heaven** is my brother, and sister, and mother."

# WEDNESDAY

## CYCLE 1

**First Reading.** *1 Chron. 22: 5 – 19*

*David prepares the construction of the Temple.*

**A reading from the first book of Chronicles.**

For David said, "Solomon my son is young and inexperienced, and the house that is to be built for the LORD must be exceedingly magnificent, of fame and glory throughout all lands; I will therefore make preparation for it." So David provided materials in great quantity before his death.

Then he called for Solomon his son, and charged him to build a house for the LORD, the God of Israel. David said to Solomon, "My son, I had it in my heart to build a house to the name of the LORD my God. But the word of the LORD came to me, saying, 'You have shed much blood and have waged great wars; you shall not build a house to my name, because you have shed so much blood before me upon the earth. Behold, a son shall be born to you; he shall be a man of peace. I will give him peace from all his enemies round about; for his name shall be Solomon, and I will give peace and quiet to Israel in his days. He shall build a house for my name. He shall be my son, and I will be his father, and I will establish his royal throne in Israel for ever.'

Now, my son, the LORD be with you, so that you may succeed in building the house of the LORD your God, as he has spoken concerning you. Only, may the LORD grant you discretion and understanding, that when he gives you charge over Israel you may keep the law of the LORD your God. Then you will prosper if you are careful to observe the statutes and the ordinances which the LORD commanded Moses for Israel. Be strong, and of good courage. Fear not; be not dismayed.

With great pains I have provided for the house of the LORD a hundred thousand talents of gold, a million talents of silver, and bronze and iron beyond weighing, for there is so much of it; timber and stone too I have provided. To these you must add. You have an abundance of workmen: stonecutters, masons, carpenters, and all kinds of craftsmen without number, skilled in working gold, silver, bronze, and iron. Arise and be doing! The LORD be with you!"

David also commanded all the leaders of Israel to help Solomon his son, saying, "Is not the LORD your God with you? And has he not given you peace on every side? For he has delivered the inhabitants of the land into my hand; and the land is subdued before the LORD and his people. Now set your mind and heart to seek the LORD your God. Arise and build the sanctuary of the LORD God, so that the Ark of the Covenant of the LORD and the holy vessels of God may be brought into a house built for the name of the LORD."

**Responsorial.** *Cfr. 1 Chr. 22: 19; Ps. 131: 7; Is. 56: 7*

**R:** Construct the sanctuary of the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul. \* Let us enter into his dwelling, let us prostrate ourselves at his feet.

**V:** The Lord said: My house will be called a house of prayer for all nations.

**R:** Let us enter into his dwelling, let us prostrate ourselves at his feet.

**Second Reading.** *Nm. 12: 13 – 14*

*God's temple is holy, and you are this temple.*

**A reading from the "Commentary on psalm 118" of St. Ambrose, bishop.**

"The Father and I will come and make our home with him. Let your door be open to him when he comes, open your soul, throw open your inmost mind, so that it may see the riches of simplicity, the treasures of peace, the sweetness of grace. Open your heart, meet the sun of eternal light that enlightens every man. The true light indeed shines on all; but if anyone has closed his windows, he will rob himself of the eternal light. Christ too is shut out if you close the door of your mind. Although he is able to enter, he does not wish to rush in uninvited. He does not wish to force the reluctant.

Born of the Virgin, he came forth from the womb, casting his rays over all things in the whole world, that he might give light to all. All receive him who long for the brightness of eternal light that no night can interrupt. The

sun which we see every day is followed by the darkness of night; but the Sun of righteousness never sets, for wickedness does not hide wisdom.

Blessed, therefore, is that man at whose door Christ knocks. Our door is faith, which, if it is strong, fortifies the whole house. It is through this door that Christ comes in. this is why the Church says in the Song of Songs: 'My brother is knocking at the door. I hear his voice'. Listen to him as he knocks and wishes to enter: 'Open to me, my sister, my love, my perfect one, for my head is wet with dew, and my locks with the drops of the night'.

You notice that God the Word knocks most insistently at your door when his head is wet with the dew of the night. In fact he deigns to visit those who are being tempted and in tribulation that no one may fall, overwhelmed by distress. Therefore his head is wet with dew or moisture when his body is in travail. You must keep awake then so that when the bridegroom comes, he may not depart because he has been shut out. For if you are asleep and your heart is not awake, he goes away without knocking; if your heart is awake, he knocks and asks for the door to be opened to him.

So then we have a door to our soul, and we have gates too, of which it is said: 'Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O eternal gates! That the King of glory may come in'. If you are willing to lift up these gates of your faith, the King of glory will come in to you, bearing the triumph of his own passion. Righteousness, too, has gates. In fact we read of these also in the scriptures, in the words of the Lord Jesus spoken through the prophet: 'Open to me the gates of righteousness'.

**Responsorial.** *Rev. 3: 20; Mt. 24: 46*

**R:** Listen! I stand at the door and knock; if anyone hears my voice and opens the door, \* I will come into his house and eat with him, and he will eat with me.

**V:** How happy is that servant if his master finds him doing this when he comes home.

**R:** I will come into his house and eat with him, and he will eat with me.

## CYCLE 2

### **First Reading** *Job 18: 1 – 21*

*Discourse of Bildad: the light of the wicked will be put off*

Then Bildad the Shuhite answered: "How long will you hunt for words? Consider, and then we will speak. Why are we counted as cattle? Why are we stupid in your sight? You who tear yourself in your anger, shall the earth be forsaken for you, or the rock be removed out of its place? "Yes, the light of the wicked is put out, and the flame of his fire does not shine. The light is dark in his tent, and his lamp above him is put out. His strong steps are shortened and his own schemes throw him down. He is cast into a net by his own feet, and he walks on a pitfall. A trap seizes him by the heel; a snare lays hold of him. A rope is hid for him in the ground, a trap for him in the path. Terrors frighten him on every side, and chase him at his heels. His strength is hunger-bitten, and calamity is ready for his stumbling. By disease his skin is consumed, the first-born of death consumes his limbs. He is torn from the tent in which he trusted, and is brought to the king of terrors. In his tent dwells that which is none of his; brimstone is scattered upon his habitation. His roots dry up beneath, and his branches wither above. His memory perishes from the earth, and he has no name in the street. He is thrust from light into darkness, and driven out of the world.

He has no offspring or descendant among his people and no survivor where he used to live. They of the west are appalled at his day, and horror seizes them of the east. Surely such are the dwellings of the ungodly; such is the place of him who knows not God."

### **Responsorial** *Job 9: 12- 14; Rom 9: 20*

**R:** If God snatches a prize, who could prevent him, or dare to say to him, 'What are you doing?' God never goes back on his anger: Rahab's minions still lie at his feet. \* How dare I plead my cause, then.

**V:** Could the pot dare to say to the potter who has made it: "Why did you make me this shape?"

**R:** How dare I plead my cause, then.

**Second Reading** *Book 11: 2: 3 – 3:5*

*Look, your voice is my joy*

**A reading from the “Confessions” of St. Augustine, bishop**

“The day is Yours, and the night also is Yours.” At your nod the moments flee by. Grant thereof space for our meditations amongst the hidden things of your law, nor close it against us who knock.

For not in vain have you willed that the obscure secret of so many pages should be written. Nor is it that those forests have not their harts, sheltering themselves therein, and refreshing, and walking, and feeding, lying down, and ruminating.

Perfect me, O Lord, and reveal them unto me. Behold, your voice is my joy, your voice surpasses the abundance of pleasures. Give that which I love, for I do love; and this have you given. Abandon not your own gifts, nor despise your grass that thirsts. Let me confess unto you whatsoever I shall have found in your books, and let me hear the voice of praise, and let me imbibe you, and reflect on the wonderful things of your law; even from the beginning, wherein you made the heaven and the earth, unto the everlasting kingdom of your holy city that is with you.

Lord, have mercy on me and hear my desire. For I think that it is not of the earth, nor of gold and silver, and precious stones, nor gorgeous apparel, nor honors and powers, nor the pleasures of the flesh, nor necessities for the body, in this pilgrimage of our life all of which are added to those that seek your kingdom and your righteousness.

Behold, O Lord my God, whence is my desire? The unrighteous have told me of delights, but not such as your law, O Lord. Behold, whence is my desire? Behold, Father, look and see, and approve; and let it be pleasing in the sight of your mercy, that I may find grace before you, that the secret things of your Word may be opened unto me when I knock? I beseech, by our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, “the Man of your right hand, the Son of man, whom you made strong for yourself,” as your Mediator and ours, through whom you have sought us, although not seeking you, but did seek us that we might seek you, — your Word through whom you have made all

things, and amongst them me also, your Only-begotten, through whom you have called to adoption the believing people, and therein me also. I beseech you through Him, who sits at your right hand, and “makes intercession for us,” “in whom are hid all treasures of wisdom and knowledge”. Him do I seek in your books. Of Him did Moses write; this He Himself said; this the Truth said. Let me hear and understand how in the beginning you did make the heaven and the earth. Moses wrote this; he wrote and departed, — passed hence from you to you. Nor now is he before me; for if he were I would hold him, and ask him, and would adjure him by you that he would open unto me these things, and I would lend the ears of my body to the sounds bursting forth from his mouth. And should he speak in the Hebrew tongue, in vain would it beat on my senses, nor would ought touch my mind; but if in Latin, I should know what he said. But whence should I know whether he said what was true? But if I knew this even, should I know it from him? Truly within me, within in the chamber of my thought, Truth, neither Hebrew, nor Greek, nor Latin, nor barbarian, without the organs of voice and tongue, without the sound of syllables, would say, “He speaks the truth,” and I, forthwith assured of it, confidently would say unto that man of yours, “you speak the truth.” As, then, I cannot inquire of him, I beseech you, — you, O Truth, full of whom he spoke truth, — you, my God, I beseech, forgive my sins; and do you, who did give to that your servant to speak these things, grant to me also to understand them.

**Responsorial.** *Confess. 10: 27; Lk. 19: 10*

**R:** Too late have I loved you, beauty always old and always new! \* You have called, you have cried and you have overcome my deafness.

**V:** The Son of man has come to search for and to save that which was lost.

**R:** You have called, you have cried and you have overcome my deafness.

**Gospel.** *Mt. 13: 1 – 9*

*Part of the seed fell on good land and bore fruit.*

**A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.**

That same day Jesus went out of the house and sat beside the sea. And great crowds gathered about him, so that he got into a boat and sat there; and the whole crowd stood on the beach.



And he told them many things in parables, saying: "A sower went out to sow. And as he sowed, some seeds fell along the path, and the birds came and devoured them. Other seeds fell on rocky ground, where they had not much soil, and immediately they sprang up, since they had no depth of soil, but when the sun rose they were scorched; and since they had no root they withered away. Other seeds fell upon thorns, and the thorns grew up and choked them. Other seeds fell on good soil and brought forth grain, some a hundredfold, some sixty, some thirty. He who has ears, let him hear."

# THURSDAY

## CYCLE 1

**First Reading.** *1 Kings 1: 11 – 35; 2: 10 – 12*

*David chooses Solomon as his successor.*

**A reading from the first book of Kings.**

Then Nathan said to Bathshe'ba the mother of Solomon, "Have you not heard that Adoni'jah the son of Haggith has become king and David our lord does not know it? Now therefore come, let me give you counsel, that you may save your own life and the life of your son Solomon. Go in at once to King David, and say to him, 'Did you not, my lord the king, swear to your maidservant, saying, "Solomon your son shall reign after me, and he shall sit upon my throne"? Why then is Adoni'jah king?'

Then while you are still speaking with the king, I also will come in after you and confirm your words." So Bathshe'ba went to the king into his chamber (now the king was very old, and Ab'ishag the Shu'nammite was ministering to the king).

Bathshe'ba bowed and did obeisance to the king, and the king said, "What do you desire?" She said to him, "My lord, you swore to your maidservant by the LORD your God, saying, 'Solomon your son shall reign after me, and he shall sit upon my throne.' And now, behold, Adoni'jah is king, although you, my lord the king, do not know it. He has sacrificed oxen, fatlings, and sheep in abundance, and has invited all the sons of the king, Abi'athar the priest, and Jo'ab the commander of the army; but Solomon your servant he has not invited. And now, my lord the king, the eyes of all Israel are upon you, to tell them who shall sit on the throne of my lord the king after him. Otherwise it will come to pass, when my lord the king sleeps with his fathers, that I and my son Solomon will be counted offenders."

While she was still speaking with the king, Nathan the prophet came in. And they told the king, "Here is Nathan the prophet." And when he came in before the king, he bowed before the king, with his face to the ground. And Nathan said, "My lord the king, have you said, 'Adoni'jah shall reign after me, and he shall sit upon my throne'? For he has gone down this day, and has sacrificed oxen, fatlings, and sheep in abundance, and has invited all the

king's sons, Jo'ab the commander of the army, and Abi'athar the priest; and behold, they are eating and drinking before him, and saying, 'Long live King Adoni'jah!' But me, your servant, and Zadok the priest, and Benai'ah the son of Jehoi'ada, and your servant Solomon, he has not invited. Has this thing been brought about by my lord the king and you have not told your servants who should sit on the throne of my lord the king after him?"

Then King David answered, "Call Bathshe'ba to me." So she came into the king's presence, and stood before the king. And the king swore, saying, "As the LORD lives, who has redeemed my soul out of every adversity, as I swore to you by the LORD, the God of Israel, saying, 'Solomon your son shall reign after me, and he shall sit upon my throne in my stead'; even so will I do this day." Then Bathshe'ba bowed with her face to the ground, and did obeisance to the king, and said, "May my lord King David live for ever!"

King David said, "Call to me Zadok the priest, Nathan the prophet, and Benai'ah the son of Jehoi'ada." So they came before the king. And the king said to them, "Take with you the servants of your lord, and cause Solomon my son to ride on my own mule, and bring him down to Gihon; and let Zadok the priest and Nathan the prophet there anoint him king over Israel; then blow the trumpet, and say, 'Long live King Solomon!' You shall then come up after him, and he shall come and sit upon my throne; for he shall be king in my stead; and I have appointed him to be ruler over Israel and over Judah."

Then David slept with his fathers, and was buried in the city of David. And the time that David reigned over Israel was forty years; he reigned seven years in Hebron, and thirty-three years in Jerusalem.

So Solomon sat upon the throne of David his father; and his kingdom was firmly established.

**Responsorial.** *Sg. Of Sgs. 3: 11; Ps. 71: 1-2*

**R:** Come out, daughters of Sion, look at your King Solomon with the crown that his mother placed on him \* on the day of the joy of his heart.

**V:** God, give to the king your justice; rule your poor with uprightness,

**R:** on the day of the joy of his heart.

**Second Reading.** *Hom. 17:1 – 4*

*Through the anointing received, the Christians are consecrated forever in the cross of Christ.*

**A reading from an ancient homily of the IVth century.**

The perfect Christians, who are retained worthy of reaching the highest grade of perfection and becoming familiar with the king, are consecrated forever to the cross of Christ. As in fact at the time of the prophets the anointing was a rite that was very precious, ordered to consecrate the kings and the prophets, so also now the spiritual men, marked by the heavenly anointing, are made Christians through grace, in order to become they themselves kings and prophets of the divine mysteries. In fact, it is exactly these who are the children, the lords, the gods: the slaves, the prisoners, the despised, the crucified, the consecrated. If the anointing done with the oil, which is taken from an earthly and visible plant, was so efficacious that it conferred an unequalled dignity to those who received it – it was in fact established that from the anointing the same kings were consecrated – and if the same David, as soon as he was anointed by this oil, was immediately the object of persecution and suffering, and only after seven years was consecrated king: how much more will those who are anointed according to the interior man with the spiritual and heavenly oil, oil of sanctification and of exultation, receive the mark of that incorruptible king and the pledge of eternal life, which is the same Holy Spirit Paraclete?

These anointed with the oil extracted from the wood of life, Jesus Christ, and from the heavenly plant, are rendered suitable to reach the height of perfection, that is of the kingdom and of the adoption; in fact those who are intimate with the king of heaven, and anchored to the faith in the Almighty, enter already in this world into his palace, there where the angels and the spirits of the saints dwell. Even if they do not as yet possess the inheritance prepared for them in the future age in its fullness, yet from the pledge that they have received they are made extremely certain, as if they were already crowned and were in possession of the keys of the kingdom; and neither do they marvel as if it was unusual and new to be called to reign with Christ, thanks to the Holy Spirit that fills them with faith. And in what way? Because, while they still live on the earth, they are possessed by that gentleness and sweetness, by that strength that belongs to the Holy Spirit.

For the Christians called to reign in the future age, there will not be anything that is new or unexpected, since already before they have been able to know the mysteries of grace, when in fact man disobeyed the command of the Lord, the devil covered with a dark veil his soul: but grace intervened and tore off that veil, in a way that the soul, restored to its original purity and to the form of its own nature, that is of a pure and irreproachable creature, could fix its eyes forever on the glory of the true light, the true Sun of justice, shining with bright light in the intimacy of the heart. And like at the end of the world that is destined to perish, the just in the future kingdom will be overwhelmed by the splendour of the glory in contemplating, according to the promise, uniquely the eternally glorious Christ at the right hand of the Father; in the same way those who from this world are taken up and welcomed into the eternal dwellings, contemplate all that there is which is of beauty and worthy of admiration. We in fact, though still being on the earth, have our citizenship in heaven, living according to our interior man, as if we were already in eternity.

**Responsorial.** *1 Jn. 2: 20, 27; 2 Cor. 1: 21-22*

**R:** You have the anointing that you have received from the Holy One, and all have the knowledge. \* But you have not lost the anointing that he gave you, and you do not need anyone to teach you, the anointing he gave teaches you everything.

**V:** It is God himself who has anointed us, marking us with his seal and giving us the pledge, the Spirit that we carry in our hearts.

**R:** But you have not lost the anointing that he gave you, and you do not need anyone to teach you, the anointing he gave teaches you everything.

## CYCLE 2

**First Reading.** *Jb. 19: 1 – 29*

*Job desperate lifts himself to hope.*

**A reading from the book of Job.**

Then Job answered: "How long will you torment me, and break me in pieces with words? These ten times you have cast reproach upon me; are you not ashamed to wrong me? And even if it were true that I have erred,

my error remains with myself. If indeed you magnify yourselves against me, and make my humiliation an argument against me, know then that God has put me in the wrong, and closed his net about me.

Behold, I cry out, 'Violence!' but I am not answered; I call aloud, but there is no justice. He has walled up my way, so that I cannot pass, and he has set darkness upon my paths. He has stripped from me my glory, and taken the crown from my head. He breaks me down on every side, and I am gone, and my hope has he pulled up like a tree. He has kindled his wrath against me, and counts me as his adversary. His troops come on together; they have cast up siege works against me, and encamp round about my tent. "He has put my brethren far from me, and my acquaintances are wholly estranged from me. My kinsfolk and my close friends have failed me; the guests in my house have forgotten me; my maidservants count me as a stranger; I have become an alien in their eyes. I call to my servant, but he gives me no answer; I must beseech him with my mouth. I am repulsive to my wife, loathsome to the sons of my own mother. Even young children despise me; when I rise they talk against me. All my intimate friends abhor me, and those whom I loved have turned against me. My bones cleave to my skin and to my flesh, and I have escaped by the skin of my teeth. Have pity on me, have pity on me, O you my friends, for the hand of God has touched me! Why do you, like God, pursue me? Why are you not satisfied with my flesh? "Oh that my words were written! Oh that they were inscribed in a book! Oh that with an iron pen and lead they were graven in the rock forever! **For I know that my Redeemer lives, and at last he will stand upon the earth; and after my skin has been thus destroyed, then from my flesh I shall see God, whom I shall see on my side, and my eyes shall behold, and not another.** My heart faints within me! If you say, 'How we will pursue him!' and, 'The root of the matter is found in him'; be afraid of the sword, for wrath brings the punishment of the sword, that you may know there is a judgment."

**Responsorial.** *Jb. 19: 25, 27*

**R:** This I know, that my Avenger lives, and he, the Last, will take his stand on earth! \* With my flesh, I will see God.

**V:** I will see him, and my eyes will contemplate him not as a stranger.

**R:** With my flesh, I will see God.

**Second Reading.** *Book 13: 1: 1 – 2: 3*

*You called me so that I could invoke you.*

**A reading from the “Confessions” of St. Augustine, bishop.**

I call upon you, my God, my mercy, who made me, and who did not forget me, though forgetful of you. I call you into my soul, which by the desire which you inspire in it you prepare it for your reception. Do not forsake me who call upon you, who did anticipate me before, I called, and did importunately urge with manifold calls that I should hear you from afar, and be converted, and call upon you who called me.

For you, O Lord, have blotted out all my evil actions, that you might not render into my hands that which I have done far from you, and you have anticipated all my good actions, that you might reward the work of your hands with which you made me; because before I was, you were, nor was I [anything] to which you might grant being. And yet behold, I am, out of your goodness, anticipating all this which you have made me, and of which you have made me. For neither had you stood in need of me, nor am I such a good as to be helpful unto you, my Lord and God; not that I may so serve you as though you were fatigued in working, or lest your power may be less if lacking my assistance nor that, like the land, I may so cultivate you that you would be uncultivated did I cultivate you not but that I may serve and worship you, to the end that I may have well-being from you; from whom it is that I am one susceptible of well-being.

For of the plenitude of your goodness your creature subsists, that a good, which could profit you nothing, nor though of you was equal to you, might yet be, since it could be made of you. For what did heaven and earth, which you made in the beginning, deserve of you? Let those spiritual and corporeal natures, which you in your wisdom made, declare what they deserve of you to depend thereon, — even the inchoate and formless, each in its own kind, either spiritual or corporeal, going into excess, and into remote unlikeness unto you (the spiritual, though formless, more excellent than if it were a formed body; and the corporeal, though formless, more excellent than if it were altogether nothing), and thus they as formless would depend upon your Word, unless by the same Word they were recalled to your Unity, and endowed with form, and from you, the one sovereign

Good, were all made very good. How have they deserved of you, that they should be even formless, since they would not be even this except from you?

How has corporeal matter deserved of you, to be even invisible and formless, since it were not even this had you not made it; and therefore since it was not, it could not deserve of you that it should be made? Or how could the inchoate spiritual creature deserve of you, that even it should flow darkly like the deep,- unlike you, had it not been by the same Word turned to that by Whom it was created, and by Him so enlightened become light, although not equally, yet conformably to that Form which is equal unto you? For as to a body, to be is not all one with being beautiful, for then it could not be deformed; so also to a created spirit, to live is not all one with living wisely, for then it would be wise unchangeably. But it is good for it always to hold fast unto you, lest, in turning from you, it lose that light which it has obtained in turning to you, and relapse into a light resembling the dark deep. **For even we ourselves, who in respect of the soul are a spiritual creature, having turned away from you, our light, were in that life 'sometimes darkness' and do labor amidst the remains of our darkness, until in your Only One we become your righteousness, like the mountains of God. For we have been your judgments, which are like the great deep.**

**Responsorial.** *Ps. 24: 4-5; Rm. 7: 14, 15*

**R:** Let me know, Lord, your ways, teach me your paths. \* Guide me in your truth and instruct me, because you are the God of my salvation.

**V:** I am of the flesh, sold as a slave to sin. I am unable to understand what I do.

**R:** Guide me in your truth and instruct me, because you are the God of my salvation.

**Gospel.** *Mt. 13: 10 – 17*

*To you is revealed the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven. But not to them.*

**A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.**

Then the disciples came and said to him, "Why do you speak to them in parables?" And he answered them, "To you it has been given to know the secrets of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it has not been given. For to



him who has will more be given, and he will have abundance; but from him who has not, even what he has will be taken away.

This is why I speak to them in parables, because seeing they do not see, and hearing they do not hear, nor do they understand. With them indeed is fulfilled the prophecy of Isaiah that says: 'You shall indeed hear but never understand, and you shall indeed see but never perceive. For this people's heart has grown dull, and their ears are heavy of hearing, and their eyes they have closed, lest they should perceive with their eyes, and hear with their ears, and understand with their heart, and turn for me to heal them.'

But blessed are your eyes, for they see, and your ears, for they hear. Truly, I say to you, many prophets and righteous men longed to see what you see, and did not see it, and to hear what you hear, and did not hear it.

# FRIDAY

## CYCLE 1

**First Reading.** *1 Kings. 3: 5 – 28*

*Inauguration of the kingdom of Solomon.*

**A reading from the first book of Kings.**

At Gibeon the LORD appeared to Solomon in a dream by night; and God said, "Ask what I shall give you." And Solomon said, "You have shown great and steadfast love to your servant David my father, because he walked before you in faithfulness, in righteousness, and in uprightness of heart toward you; and you have kept for him this great and steadfast love, and have given him a son to sit on his throne this day. And now, O LORD my God, you have made your servant king in place of David my father, although I am but a little child; I do not know how to go out or come in. And your servant is in the midst of your people whom you have chosen, a great people, which cannot be numbered or counted for multitude. Give your servant therefore an understanding mind to govern your people, that I may discern between good and evil; for who is able to govern this your great people?"

It pleased the Lord that Solomon had asked this. And God said to him, "Because you have asked this, and have not asked for yourself long life or riches or the life of your enemies, but have asked for yourself understanding to discern what is right, behold, I now do according to your word. Behold, I give you a wise and discerning mind, so that none like you has been before you and none like you shall arise after you. I give you also what you have not asked, both riches and honour, so that no other king shall compare with you, all your days. And if you will walk in my ways, keeping my statutes and my commandments, as your father David walked, then I will lengthen your days."

And Solomon awoke, and behold, it was a dream. Then he came to Jerusalem, and stood before the Ark of the Covenant of the LORD, and offered up burnt offerings and peace offerings, and made a feast for all his servants.

Then two harlots came to the king, and stood before him. The one woman said, "Oh, my lord, this woman and I dwell in the same house; and I

gave birth to a child while she was in the house. Then on the third day after I was delivered, this woman also gave birth; and we were alone; there was no one else with us in the house, only we two were in the house. And this woman's son died in the night, because she lay on it. And she arose at midnight, and took my son from beside me, while your maidservant slept, and laid it in her bosom, and laid her dead son in my bosom. When I rose in the morning to nurse my child, behold, it was dead; but when I looked at it closely in the morning, behold, it was not the child that I had borne." But the other woman said, "No, the living child is mine, and the dead child is yours." The first said, "No, the dead child is yours, and the living child is mine." Thus they spoke before the king.

Then the king said, "The one says, 'This is my son that is alive, and your son is dead'; and the other says, 'No; but your son is dead, and my son is the living one.'" And the king said, "Bring me a sword." So a sword was brought before the king. And the king said, "Divide the living child in two, and give half to the one, and half to the other."

Then the woman whose son was alive said to the king, because her heart yearned for her son, "Oh, my lord, give her the living child, and by no means slay it." But the other said, "It shall be neither mine nor yours; divide it." Then the king answered and said, "Give the living child to the first woman, and by no means slay it; she is its mother."

And all Israel heard of the judgment that the king had rendered; and they stood in awe of the king, because they perceived that the wisdom of God was in him, to render justice.

**Responsorial.** *Cfr. 1 Kg. 3: 11, 12, 13; Lk. 12: 31*

**R:** God said to Solomon: Because you have not asked for a long life for yourself, nor riches, but have asked for wisdom for yourself. \* Behold, I grant you a wise and intelligent heart, and also riches and glory.

**V:** Search rather for the kingdom of God, and all these things will be given to you as well.

**R:** Behold, I grant you a wise and intelligent heart, and also riches and glory.

**Second Reading.** *Hom. 7*

*The peaceful king governs with justice his people.*

## **A reading from the “Homilies on the Song of Songs” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.**

In many aspects King Solomon represents the type of the true king; I speak of the many things that the sacred Scripture refers of him, with regard to what he had that was good. It says in fact that he is peace loving, and gifted with profound wisdom, that he built the temple, that he reigned over Israel and judged the people with equity; and that he is of the descent of David. To him, then the queen of Ethiopia comes. All these things, and other similar ones, are said about him in figure, but describe the power of the gospel.

In fact who is that man who loves peace so much that he destroyed all enmity nailing on the cross his enemies, and reconciled us to himself together with the whole world? He, who knocked down “the wall of separation in order to create in himself, of the two, only one new man, making peace” (Ep. 2: 14, 15) is the one who announces peace to those who are far away and to those who are close, through those who proclaim good.

Who then is the one who builds that temple “Whose foundations are on the holy mountains” (Ps. 86: 1), that is, as the Apostle says, builds “on the foundation of the apostles and the prophets” (Ep. 2: 20) with stones that have life and spirit in him?

They grow in him well ordered because of the compactness of the building, as the prophet says (cfr, Is. 28: 16), so that, well structured and connected (cfr Ep. 4: 16) in the strength of the faith and in the bond of peace, they are built “to be the holy temple in the Lord, so as to become the dwelling of God through the Holy Spirit” (Ep. 2: 21, 22).

That the Lord then is the king of Israel his enemies also attest when they wrote on the cross the recognition of his kingdom: “This is Jesus, the king of the Jews” (Mt. 27: 37). Let us gather the testimony, even if it seems to reduce the extension of his power limiting it to the dominion of the kingdom of the Israelites. But it is not like this: the same inscription on the cross, attributing to him the power on one part, in reality is conferred over all, because it does not add that Jesus is only king of the Jews. In fact, attesting without limits his dominion over the Jews, with the same words he assigns tacitly a universal dominion. In fact, the king of the whole earth dominates one part also.

The commitment of Solomon to judge according to truth, is then to signify the true judge of the whole world, who says: “The Father judges no one, but he has remitted all judgement to the Son” (Jn. 5: 22); and “I cannot do anything by myself; I judge according to what I hear and my judgement is just” (Jn. 5: 30). This is the most exact definition of the just judge: to give an answer to those who contest in judgement, not from himself, for some personal inclination, but first to listen to those who are subjected to the judgement, and then to pronounce the sentence in their regard. Therefore Christ, the power of God, recognises that he is not able to do certain things: in fact the truth cannot make him deviate the judgement from the justice.

Finally, who is it who can ignore that the community constituted by the nations coming from idolatry in origin was black, before becoming the Church, and that for the long time in which they were dominated by ignorance, remained far from the knowledge of the true God? But when the grace of God appeared, his wisdom shone forth, and the true light unfolded its rays on those who sat in darkness and in the shadow of death. Then, while Israel closed its eyes to the light and withdrew itself from the participation in such a great good, behold the Ethiopians came forward, they who from the nations drew near to the faith; having washed their own darkness in the mystical waters. The point has been reached when the Ethiopians have extended their hands to God (cfr. Ps. 67: 32) offering to the king their gifts: the perfumes of piety, the gold of the knowledge of God, and the precious stones of the commandments and of the virtues.

**Responsorial.** *Ps. 44: 7- 8*

**R:** Your throne, O God, lasts forever; \* the sceptre of your kingdom is a just sceptre.

**V:** You love justice and detest impiety: God, your God has consecrated you.

**R:** The sceptre of your kingdom is a just sceptre.

## CYCLE 2

**First Reading.** *Jb. 22: 1 – 30*

*Eliphaz exhorts Job to reconcile himself with God.*

**A reading from the book of Job.**

Then Eli'phaz the Te'manite answered: "Can a man be profitable to God? Surely he who is wise is profitable to himself. Is it any pleasure to the Almighty if you are righteous, or is it gain to him if you make your ways blameless? Is it for your fear of him that he reproves you, and enters into judgment with you? Is not your wickedness great? There is no end to your iniquities. For you have exacted pledges of your brothers for nothing, and stripped the naked of their clothing. You have given no water to the weary to drink, and you have withheld bread from the hungry. The man with power possessed the land, and the favoured man dwelt in it. You have sent widows away empty, and the arms of the fatherless were crushed. Therefore snares are round about you, and sudden terror overwhelms you; your light is darkened, so that you cannot see, and a flood of water covers you. "Is not God high in the heavens? See the highest stars, how lofty they are!

Therefore you say, 'What does God know? Can he judge through the deep darkness? Thick clouds enwrap him, so that he does not see, and he walks on the vault of heaven'. Will you keep to the old way which wicked men have trod? They were snatched away before their time; their foundation was washed away. They said to God, 'Depart from us' and 'What can the Almighty do to us?' Yet he filled their houses with good things -- but the counsel of the wicked is far from me. The righteous see it and are glad; the innocent laugh them to scorn, saying, 'Surely our adversaries are cut off, and what they left the fire has consumed'.

"Agree with God, and be at peace; thereby good will come to you. Receive instruction from his mouth, and lay up his words in your heart. If you return to the Almighty and humble yourself, if you remove unrighteousness far from your tents, if you lay gold in the dust, and gold of Ophir among the stones of the torrent bed, and if the Almighty is your gold, and your precious silver; then you will delight yourself in the Almighty, and lift up your face to God. You will make your prayer to him, and he will hear you; and you will pay your vows. You will decide on a matter, and it will be established for you, and light will shine on your ways. For God abases the proud, but he saves the lowly. He delivers the innocent man; you will be delivered through the cleanness of your hands."

**Responsorial.** *Jb. 22: 2, 12, 21*

**R:** Can a man be of any use to God, when even the wise man's wisdom is of use only to himself? \* Does not God live in the heights of the heaven? Look

at the zenith of the stars: how high they are!

**V:** Well then, make peace with him, be reconciled, and all your happiness will be restored to you.

**R:** Does not God live in the heights of heaven? Look at the zenith of the stars: how high they are!

**Second Reading.** *Book 13: 21: 31 – 22: 32*

*The Word of God is the source of eternal life.*

**A reading from the “Confessions” of St. Augustine, bishop.**

But your Word, O God, is the fountain of eternal life, and passes not away; therefore this departure is kept in check by your word when it is said unto us, “Be not conformed unto this world,” so that the earth may bring forth a living soul in the fountain of life, — a soul restrained in your Word, by your Evangelists, by imitating the followers of your Christ. For behold, O Lord our God, our Creator, when our affections have been restrained from the love of the world, by which we died by living ill, and began to be a “living soul” by living well; and your word which you spoke by your apostle is made good in us, “Be not conformed to this world;” next also follows that which you presently subjoined, saying, “But be you transformed by the renewing of your mind,” — not now after your kind, as if following your neighbor who went before you, nor as if living after the example of a better man (for you have not said, “Let man be made after his kind,” but, “Let us make man in our image, after our likeness”), that we may prove what your will is. For to this purpose said that dispenser of yours, — begetting children by the gospel, — that he might not always have them “babes,” whom he would feed on milk, and cherish as a nurse; “be you transformed,” said He, “by the renewing of your mind, that he may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect will of God.” Therefore you did not say, “Let man be made,” but, “Let us make man.” Nor did you say, “after his kind,” but, after “our image” and “likeness.” Because, being renewed in his mind, and beholding and apprehending your truth, man needs not man as his director that he may imitate his kind; but by your direction proves what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect will of yours. And you taught him, now made capable, to perceive the Trinity of the Unity, and the Unity of the Trinity.

And therefore this being said in the plural, “Let us make man,” it is yet subjoined in the singular, “and God made man;” and this being said in the plural, “after our likeness,” is subjoined in the singular, “after the image of God.” Thus is man renewed in the knowledge of God, after the image of Him that created him; and being made spiritual, he judges all things, — all things that are to be judged, — “yet he himself is judge of no man.”

**Responsorial** 2 Cor 5: 4, 5: 2

**R:** We groan and find it a burden being still in this body. \* This is the purpose for which God made us, and he has given us the pledge of the Spirit.

**V:** Therefore we groan as we wait with longing to put on our heavenly home over the other.

**R:** This is the purpose for which God made us, and he has given us the pledge of the Spirit.

**Gospel** Mt 13: 18 – 23

*He who listens to the word and understands it, gives fruits*

"Hear then the parable of the sower. When any one hears the word of the kingdom and does not understand it, the evil one comes and snatches away what is sown in his heart; this is what was sown along the path. As for what was sown on rocky ground, this is he who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy; yet he has no root in himself, but endures for a while, and when tribulation or persecution arises on account of the word, immediately he falls away. As for what was sown among thorns, this is he who hears the word, but the cares of the world and the delight in riches choke the word, and it proves unfruitful. As for what was sown on good soil, this is he who hears the word and understands it; he indeed bears fruit, and yields, in one case a hundredfold, in another sixty, and in another thirty."



# SATURDAY

## CYCLE 1

**First Reading.** *1 Kings 8: 1 – 21*

*Solemn dedication of the Temple.*

**A reading from the first book of Kings.**

Then Solomon assembled the elders of Israel and all the heads of the tribes, the leaders of the fathers' houses of the people of Israel, before King Solomon in Jerusalem, to bring up the Ark of the Covenant of the LORD out of the city of David, which is Zion. And all the men of Israel assembled to King Solomon at the feast in the month Eth'anim, which is the seventh month. And all the elders of Israel came, and the priests took up the ark. And they brought up the ark of the LORD, the tent of meeting, and all the holy vessels that were in the tent; the priests and the Levites brought them up.

And King Solomon and all the congregation of Israel, who had assembled before him, were with him before the ark, sacrificing so many sheep and oxen that they could not be counted or numbered. Then the priests brought the Ark of the Covenant of the LORD to its place, in the inner sanctuary of the house, in the most holy place, underneath the wings of the cherubim.

For the cherubim spread out their wings over the place of the ark, so that the cherubim made a covering above the ark and its poles. And the poles were so long that the ends of the poles were seen from the holy place before the inner sanctuary; but they could not be seen from outside; and they are there to this day. There was nothing in the ark except the two tables of stone that Moses put there at Horeb, where the LORD made a covenant with the people of Israel, when they came out of the land of Egypt.

And when the priests came out of the holy place, a cloud filled the house of the LORD, so that the priests could not stand to minister because of the cloud; for the glory of the LORD filled the house of the LORD.

Then Solomon said, "The LORD has set the sun in the heavens, but has said that he would dwell in thick darkness. I have built you an exalted house, a place for you to dwell in for ever."

Then the king faced about, and blessed all the assembly of Israel, while all the assembly of Israel stood. And he said, "Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, who with his hand has fulfilled what he promised with his mouth to David my father, saying, 'Since the day that I brought my people Israel out of Egypt, I chose no city in all the tribes of Israel in which to build a house, that my name might be there; but I chose David to be over my people Israel.' Now it was in the heart of David my father to build a house for the name of the LORD, the God of Israel. But the LORD said to David my father, 'Whereas it was in your heart to build a house for my name, you did well that it was in your heart; nevertheless you shall not build the house, but your son who shall be born to you shall build the house for my name.'

Now the LORD has fulfilled his promise which he made; for I have risen in the place of David my father, and sit on the throne of Israel, as the LORD promised, and I have built the house for the name of the LORD, the God of Israel. And there I have provided a place for the ark, in which is the covenant of the LORD which he made with our fathers, when he brought them out of the land of Egypt."

**Responsorial.** *Ws. 9: 7, 8, 4; 2 Ch. 6: 18- 19*

**R:** You, O Lord, have chosen me as king of your people and you have asked me to construct a temple on your holy mountain: \* Give me the wisdom, that sits on the throne besides you, and do not exclude me from the number of your children.

**V:** The heavens of the heavens cannot contain you, much less this house that I have constructed for you: yet turn to the prayer of your servant and listen to the plea that your servant raises to you.

**R:** Give me the wisdom, which sits on the throne besides you, and do not exclude me from the number of your children.

**Second Reading.** *Disc. 229:2*

*Let us exult, because we have become the temple of God.*

**A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Caesarius of Arles, bishop.**

"The temple of God is holy, and you are that temple" (1 Cor. 3: 17). For this the temples of wood and stones are constructed, so that in them the living temples of God gather, and thus form the unique temple of God. Every Christian is a temple of God, and many Christians are many temples

of God: you see therefore, brothers, how beautiful is the temple formed by the different temples; and as many members constitute only one body, so also many temples form one unique temple.

But these temples of Christ, that is the holy souls of the Christians, are dispersed in the entire world; when the day of judgement will come they will all be gathered together and in the eternal life they will constitute only one temple. As the multiple members of Christ make only one body and have Christ as the unique head, so also the same Christ will live in those temples, since he is our head. The Apostle in fact says: “May he give you the power through his Spirit for your hidden self to grow strong, so that Christ may live in your hearts through faith” (Ep. 3: 16, 17).

Let us exult, since we have obtained the grace to be the temple of God; but together we live in the holy fear of violating this temple of God with wicked deeds. That which the Apostle says, we fear “If anyone destroys the temple of God, God will destroy him” (1 Cor. 3 17). That God who without any effort has created the heaven and the earth with the power of his Word, has deigned to place his dwelling in you; therefore you must behave in a way so that you do not offend such a great guest. Never must the Lord find in you, that is in his temple, something that is sordid, obscure or haughty: because in the moment in which he finds in you a reason to be offended, immediately he would move away; and if the Redeemer was to leave you, immediately the deceiver would draw near to you.

Therefore, brothers, since God has wanted to make us his temple, and he has deigned to come and dwell in us, as far as we are able let us try with his help to cast away all superfluous cares and to gather instead all that is of benefit to us. If with the help of God we act in this way, then, brothers, we will be able to invite the Lord into the temple of our hearts and of our body.

**Responsorial.** *2 Mac. 14: 35-36; 1 Cor. 3: 17*

**R:** O Lord, you who stand in need of nothing at all, it has pleased you that there should be in our midst a temple for your dwelling place. \* Now therefore holy Lord of all holiness preserve forever from all profanation this your house.

**V:** If anyone destroys the temple of God, God will destroy him. Because the temple of God is holy and you are that temple.

**R:** Now therefore holy Lord of all holiness preserve forever from all profanation this your house.

## CYCLE 2

**First Reading.** *Jb. 23: 1 – 24:12*

*Job answers that the impious remain unpunished.*

**A reading from the book of Job.**

Then Job answered: "Today also my complaint is bitter, his hand is heavy in spite of my groaning. Oh, that I knew where I might find him, that I might come even to his seat! I would lay my case before him and fill my mouth with arguments. I would learn what he would answer me, and understand what he would say to me. Would he contend with me in the greatness of his power? No; he would give heed to me. There an upright man could reason with him, and I should be acquitted forever by my judge. "Behold, I go forward, but he is not there; and backward, but I cannot perceive him; on the left hand I seek him, but I cannot behold him; I turn to the right hand, but I cannot see him. But he knows the way that I take; when he has tried me, I shall come forth as gold. My foot has held fast to his steps; I have kept his way and have not turned aside. I have not departed from the commandment of his lips; I have treasured in my bosom the words of his mouth. But he is unchangeable and who can turn him? What he desires, that he does. For he will complete what he appoints for me; and many such things are in his mind. Therefore I am terrified at his presence; when I consider, I am in dread of him. God has made my heart faint; the Almighty has terrified me; for I am hemmed in by darkness, and thick darkness covers my face. "Why are not times of judgment kept by the Almighty, and why do those who know him never see his days? Men remove landmarks; they seize flocks and pasture them. They drive away the ass of the fatherless; they take the widow's ox for a pledge. They thrust the poor off the road; the poor of the earth all hide themselves.

Behold, like wild asses in the desert they go forth to their toil, seeking prey in the wilderness as food for their children. They gather their fodder in the field and they glean the vineyard of the wicked man. They lie all night naked, without clothing, and have no covering in the cold. They are wet with the rain of the mountains, and cling to the rock for want of shelter. There are those who snatch the fatherless child from the breast, and take in

pledge the infant of the poor. They go about naked, without clothing; hungry, they carry the sheaves; among the olive rows of the wicked they make oil; they tread the winepresses, but suffer thirst. From out of the city the dying groan, and the soul of the wounded cries for help; yet God pays no attention to their prayer.

**Responsorial.** *Jb. 23: 3, 10, 13*

**R:** Oh, if I could know where to find God, that I could come to his throne! \* Because he knows my conduct, if he tries me in the crucible, I will come out like pure gold.

**V:** If he chooses, who can make him change? That which he wants, he does.

**R:** Because he knows my conduct, if he tries me in the crucible, I will come out like pure gold.

**Second Reading.** *Book 13: 35: 50 – 38:53*

*Everything you have given us, O Lord: the peace of rest, the peace of the Sabbath without evening.*

**A reading from the “Confessions” of St. Augustine, bishop.**

O Lord God, grant your peace unto us, for you have supplied us with all things, — the peace of rest, the peace of the Sabbath, which has no evening. For all this most beautiful order of things, “very good” (all their courses being finished), is to pass away, for in them there was morning and evening.

But the seventh day is without any evening, nor has it any setting, because you have sanctified it to an everlasting continuance that that which you did after your works, which were very good, resting on the seventh day, although in unbroken rest you made them that the voice of your Book may speak beforehand unto us, that we also after our works (therefore very good, because you have given them unto us) may repose in you also in the Sabbath of eternal life.

For even then shall you so rest in us, as now you do work in us; and thus shall that be your rest through us, as these are your works through us. But you, O Lord, ever work, and are ever at rest. Nor do you see in time, nor do you move in time, nor do you rest in time; and yet you make the

scenes of time, and the times themselves, and the rest which results from time.

We therefore see those things that you made, because they are; but they are because you see them. And we see without that they are, and within that they are good, but you did see them there, when made, where you did see them to be made. And we were at another time moved to do well, after our hearts had conceived of your Spirit; but in the former time, forsaking you, we were moved to do evil but you, the One, the Good God, has never ceased to do good. And we also have certain good works, of your gift, but not eternal; after these we hope to rest in your great hallowing. But you, being the Good, needing no good, are ever at rest, because you yourself are your rest. And what man will teach man to understand this? Or what angel, an angel? Or what angel, a man? Let it be asked of you, sought in you, knocked for at you; so, even so shall it be received, so shall it be found, so shall it be opened. Amen.

**Responsorial.** *Ps. 16: 15; 1 Cor. 13: 12*

**R:** For me the reward of my virtue is to see your face; \* on waking I will fill myself with your presence.

**V:** Now I know in an imperfect way, but then I will know perfectly, as I also am known

**R:** On waking I will fill myself with your presence.

**Gospel.** *Mt. 13: 24 – 30*

*Let both grow together until the harvest.*

**A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.**

Another parable he put before them, saying, "The kingdom of heaven may be compared to a man who sowed good seed in his field; but while men were sleeping, his enemy came and sowed weeds among the wheat, and went away. So when the plants came up and bore grain, then the weeds appeared also. And the servants of the householder came and said to him, 'Sir, did you not sow good seed in your field? How then has it weeds?' He said to them, 'An enemy has done this.' The servants said to him, 'Then do you want us to go and gather them?' But he said, 'No; lest in gathering the weeds you root up the wheat along with them. Let both grow together until

the harvest; and at harvest time I will tell the reapers, Gather the weeds first and bind them in bundles to be burned, but gather the wheat into my barn."